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PHIL 226 - Biomedical Ethics

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The lack of trust in healthcare systems and public health initiatives among racial minority groups is a pervasive and entrenched issue that demands immediate attention and comprehensive understanding. Howard McGary's essay, "Racial Groups, Distrust, and the Distribution of Healthcare," delves into the issue of distrust among racial groups within the healthcare system. McGary emphasizes the need to acknowledge historical injustices and their impact on trust while also shedding light on addressing systemic biases and structural inequalities in healthcare. Within the essay, the "Ways to Overcome Distrust" section provides a comprehensive exploration of strategies that medical professionals can employ to address the issue of distrust towards healthcare systems, initiatives, and services among racialized groups. For this specific section or passage from the essay, the title initially seemed puzzling as it implied a direct and definite discussion of strategies to address distrust in healthcare systems, particularly among African Americans. However, upon a closer look, the passage reveals an exploration of the factors that contribute to non-African American physicians' skepticism toward the potential effectiveness of considering minority distrust as a means of improving medical practices. The author analyzes the need for systemic and institutional changes that can help physicians address their unconscious racial biases.

As a whole, McGary's essay explores the origins of mistrust towards the social institutional structure of healthcare by African Americans, closely focusing on the system itself

and its professionals. He discusses the gradual decline of trust in a sociohistorical context that African-Americans experienced in the hands of the healthcare system and the people behind it, during and long after slavery was abolished and highlights the importance of acknowledging and addressing historical injustices, promoting cultural competence, fostering trust-building interactions, enhancing communication, and creating equitable healthcare policies in an aim to mitigate distrust and improve the healthcare experiences of marginalized communities. In the chosen passage, McGary explores the challenges of addressing minority distrust in the healthcare system—the main one being convincing non-African American doctors to address the problem—and proposes potential solutions. McGary identifies ethical relativism, implicit racial biases, paternalistic attitudes, and competing priorities as factors that develop uncertainty among physicians regarding the effectiveness of reflecting on minority distrust in enhancing their behaviours as healthcare providers. The passage emphasizes the importance of recognizing and overcoming these obstacles, highlighting the need to address minority distrust for the sake of equitable healthcare delivery.

Through highlighting the significance of acknowledging and surmounting challenges to ensure equitable and inclusive healthcare provision, the “Ways to Overcome Distrust” passage of the essay demonstrates the significant role it plays in addressing the pervasive issue of racial distrust within healthcare systems, making it a crucial contribution to the study of biomedical ethics. It emphasizes the urgent need for acknowledgment and lasting solutions to address this problem. Ethicists, healthcare workers, and researchers should engage with this passage to gain a deeper understanding of the underlying factors that contribute to distrust and to develop effective and long-term strategies for mitigating its effects, as well as quickly identify the emerging problematic facets of certain proposed solutions. It underscores the importance of medical

professionals, especially physicians, to reflect on their own biases and practices, along with implementing systemic changes to address the long-term harms caused by systematic medical maltreatment and malpractice against minorities. Moreover, the passage highlights the significance of having physicians who are representative of and connected to the communities they serve. Ultimately, this passage emphasizes the need to consider various social and historical aspects of the healthcare system to address and overcome racial distrust. It reinforces the understanding that addressing distrust should begin with individual professionals, and this understanding is what leads to systemic solutions.

Upon close examination, the passage reveals compelling strategies for addressing racial distrust in healthcare, aligning harmoniously with the overarching arguments presented in the essay. The author skillfully underscores the importance of acknowledging historical injustices and their enduring impact on trust. Through the incorporation of cultural competence and improved communication, the passage acknowledges the imperative of adopting a patient-centred approach. The argument outlined in the passage is both plausible and relevant, as the proposed strategies align with the empirical evidence and ethical principles outlined, aiming to enhance trust and improve healthcare outcomes. With the premises supporting the argument, such as the recognition of historical injustices and the need for cultural competence, they are soundly validated and thus culminate in a strong conclusion that prioritizes equitable and just healthcare practices. Conceptually, the passage's discussion manages to capture the intricacies of the issue at hand without succumbing to unnecessary opacity. The author effectively explores the multifaceted nature of racial distrust and presents a comprehensive framework for its resolution within the healthcare system. While one might critique the passage for not explicitly outlining the specific steps required to overcome distrust, being inconsistent with its title, closer

examination reveals that McGary delves deeply into holistically addressing these problems, suggesting that comprehensive solutions parallel a broader approach, much more beyond a simple list of actions. The clear conceptual analysis successfully encapsulates the complexities of the issue, while McGary's contribution to the study of biomedical ethics manifests in the exploration of challenges and potential remedies pertaining to racial distrust within the healthcare system.

Reference

McGary, H. (2002). Racial Groups, Distrust, and the Distribution of Health Care. In R. Rhodes, M. Battin, & A. Silvers (Eds.), *Medicine and Social Justice: Essays on the Distribution of Health Care* (pp. 212–223). Essay, Oxford University Press.